# First Congregational Church
## of Los Angeles

## *Fall Series 8*
## *Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Feminine*

### *25 October 2026*



*Mary of the Gael Stained Glass ~ From Saint Brigid of Kildare School*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

## The Gathering of the People

*First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~*

*Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.*

**Organ Prelude Concert** **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*

Improvisation on SALVE REGINA COELITUM and LASST UNS ERFREUEN
Duo (Elizabeth von Herzogenberg)
Carriage Without A Driver (Philip Glass)
O Virtus Sapientiae (Hildegard von Bingen, arr. C. Bull)
Fugue in D minor, BWV 565/2 (Johann Sebastian Bach)
O Fortuna (Carl Orff)

**Chiming of the Hour**

**Welcome** **Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

**Words of Gathering** **Cynthia Siadat & Rev. Fregin**

In the midst of wind and fire,
rain and thunderclaps,
mist and darkness,
we feel our hearts opening.

Softened by the turbulent powers,
like hard earth now turning easily
on the blade of a plow,
hope sows itself into our heart's deep crevices.

There it remains, nurtured in some mysterious
way ready to burst forth
into some long-distant, shadowed day.

If it be fear that opens us to hope,
then fill us with it!

If it be love that sows it in our hearts,
then let us feel love's drenching presence!

If it be faith that nurtures seeds already sown,
then give us strength to wait the day
when faith is all we have and all we need!

***O Holy Moment,***
***in the places where we live our lives and find meaning,***
***plant within each one of us, seeds with endless hearts,***
***as you ground us in your presence and call us to grow.***

[gv/adaptedlvf]

May it be so.
***May it be so for us!***

***Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering***

***Hymn of Gathering** ***To You, O God, All Creatures Sing*** LASST UNS ERFREUEN

To you, O God, all creatures sing,
And all creation, everything
Sings your praises, alleluia!
Your burning sun with golden beam,
Your silver moon with softer gleam
Sing your praises, alleluia,
Alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your wind that blows the tempest by,
Your clouds that's sail across the sky
Sing your praises, alleluia!
Your morning rises with a song,
And lights of evening sing along,
Sing your praises, alleluia,
Alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your flowing waters, crystal clear,
Make melodies for you to hear,
Sings your praises, alleluia!
Your fire…bountiful and bright,
Remembering your warmth and light,
Sing your praises, alleluia,
Alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

To you, O God, day after day,
Your planet earth in every way,
Sing your praises, alleluia!
As savory fruit and fragrant flower
Show forth your glory and your power,
Singing praises, alleluia,
Alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

-text adapted by Miriam Therese Winter

***Prayer of Awareness** **Rev. Fregin**

Christ, our Light,
with every morning
you welcome us in the world,
and with your lavish care
you meet our hunger and thirst.

On this day, help us sense the feast
you have placed within this hour -
on this hallowed, holy,
blessed day.

May it be so.
***May it be so for all of us!***
***Amen and Amen.***

***Introit** When Morning Gilds the Skies LAUDES DOMINI, arr. SHARON CHEEK
Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Bells Soloist*

***The Lord's Prayer** **Cynthia Siadat**

***Our [Mother],***
***who is in heaven with us,***
***we call upon your names.***
***Your wisdom come.***
***Your will be done,***
***in all the spaces in which you dwell.***
***Give us each day***
***sustenance and perseverance.***
***Remind us of our limits as***
***we give grace to the limits of others.***
***Separate us from the temptation of empire,***
***and deliver us into community.***
***For you are the dwelling place within us,***
***the empowerment around us,***
***and the celebration among us,***
***now and forever. Amen.*** [Grace Cathedral, Womanist Lord's Prayer Beyoncé Mass]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace** **Rev. Fregin**

When the path is simple, peace.
When the way is complicated, peace.
May Christ not only show us the way
but also be the way we travel:
way of blessing, way of peace.
[Jan Richardson - *The Sanctuary of Women*]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
***And also with you!***

*You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow*

***Please be seated***

**Reading from Our Religious Tradition** **Rev. Fregin & Cynthia Siadat**
***from the Wisdom of Sirach***

This is the witness of the ancients…
***Thanks be to God!***

**Prayers with the People** **Rev. Michael Lehman**

**Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

***Silence***

**Prayer of Our Hearts**

For the wisdom that fashioned the universe
and can be read in the earth's dark depths
and in heaven's infinity of lights,
***Thanks be to you, O God.***

For the wisdom of teachers before us
and their words and imaginative seeing,
for the wisdom of those we have known
and their silence and humility of speech,
and for wisdom's wellspring in my own soul
and in the soul of every human being
from which ancient truths and new realizations spring forth,
***Thanks be to you.***

Let wisdom unfold in our hearts and minds
and in the people of every nation.
Let us see the foundations for a new harmony
within us and between us,
the foundations for a recovered unity
with the earth and all of its life-forms,
for the ground of life which is in you, O God,
for the ground of all life, which is in you.

In the silence of our hearts
let us give thanks for the gift of this day
as we pray for the life of the world…

In the great light that rules the day
and in the gentler light that guides the night,
may we glimpse the shinings of your presence, O God,
may we glimpse the shinings of your presence.
***Amen and Amen.***

**Meditation Anthem** TEXT & MUSIC: KASSÍA (9TH CENTURY),

The Gnomic Verses of Saint Kassía ARRANGED BY IANTHE MARINI

Ianthe Marini, Tiffany Ho, Molly Pease, Rachel Steinke, *Quartet,* Dr. Christoph Bull, *Drone*

*Wealth without friends is a dark dwelling place! I've no respect for a judge who shows favoritism to status and takes orders from influential individuals. Wealth covers sin. The poor are left naked. The greedy hoarder of wealth lives in poverty in the midst of wealth; they possess all things except those they do not know how to use.*

**Sermon** ***The Sacred Feminine*** **Rev. Lehman**

**The Eucharist and Blessings**

**Words of Invitation & Remembrance**
At this table, we bless and are blessed by these elements:
the bread and the fruit of the vine are gifts of the Earth,
they are gifts of God.

In the sharing of this holy meal,
may they become for us sacred reminders
of all that has been offered in this unfolding story,
all the sacrifices necessary to give us life,
to shape and animate our bodies, our minds, and our hearts.

In sharing this meal, we enter into a new covenant, with you,
with all creation, and with one another.
We promise to walk gently on this planet,
to give voice to those who have no voice,
to listen with our hearts,
to love kindness,
and to seek peace.

We break this bread as Jesus broke it.
We pour this cup as Jesus poured it.
And we remember that our lives are changed
each time we come together and share
the bread and the cup.

**Sharing of the Bread and the Cup**
At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

**Invitation to Generosity** **Cynthia Siadat**

May the God who dwells behind time
and the God who dwells within time
bless us with the gift of time.
May it be for us an open door,
a spacious place,
a realm of meeting,
a world of grace.

May the power of Brigid inspire us,
the grace of Brigid attend us
the flame of Brigid engage us.
And may the God who provided her
all these gifts
provide them also to us,
that we may go into the world

with her lavish generosity
and her creative fire. [Jan Richardson]

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.*

**Offertory** Vuelie FJELLHEIM & BECK, INDIGENOUS SÁMI YOIK
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer** **Cynthia Siadat**
***Thank you, Good God,***
***for all the gifts we have already received***
***from your marvelous gifts of creation,***
***and our time together on this day.***
***As we give these offerings,***
***we ask for help in using them wisely***
***and in ways that will help us,***
***bring life to all your children***
***as we honor your dream for creation,***
***more deeply.***
***Amen and Amen!***

***Please be seated***

**Life at First Church** **Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin**

**Words of Blessing** **Rev. Lehman**
May the spirit of Saint Brigid,
woman of lavish hospitality,
inspire you this day.

Amid the fragments,
may you find the wild bounty
and in every moment, a feast.

Before you, behind you,
may Christ our light
attend your way.

May it ever be so.

**Choral Response** The Song of Brigid LAURA ASH
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

***Hymn for the Journey** ***Holy Wisdom*** SALVE REGINA COELITUM

Who comes from God, as Word and Breath? Holy Wisdom.
Who holds the keys of life and death? Mighty Wisdom.
Crafter and Creator too, Eldest, she makes all things new;
Wisdom guides what God would do, Wisest One, Radiant One,
Welcome, Holy Wisdom.

Who lifts her voice for all to hear? Joyful Wisdom.
Who shapes a thought and makes it clear? Truthful Wisdom.
Teacher, drawing out our best, magnifies what we invest,
Names our truth, directs our quest. Wisest One, Radiant One,
Welcome, Holy Wisdom.

Whom should we seek with all our heart? Loving Wisdom.
Who, once revealed, will not depart? Faithful Wisdom.
Partner, Counselor, Comforter, love has found none lovelier,
Life is gladness lived with her. Wisest One, Radiant One,
Welcome, Holy Wisdom.

**Postlude** **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*
Toccata in D minor (Johann Sebastian Bach)

**Inside The Music**

The musical exploration of the day celebrates the Divine Feminine in each of us. We begin with a song of exhilaration played by Grace with the masterful technique and precision required for solo bell ringing. In this exclamation we express that the Divine Feminine rings with unabashed joy!

In meditation, we center the work of 9th century Greek nun, poet, composer, and political and religious dissident, Saint Kassiani. Her musical works are considered the first historical record of documented music composed by a female, and her poetry some of the earliest examples of feminism: fighting totalitarian imperial power, and publicly defending the agency, intellectual capacity, and dignity of women. A woman of wealth and education, Kassia fiercely defended and funded the impoverished and the imprisoned, using her private wealth to fund the underground religious resistance movement in opposition to the policies of the Byzantine Empire before relinquishing her wealth to become a nun, founding a convent of her own. A staunch dissident of the patriarchal systems of power, her writing was rooted in her fierce criticism of the systemic hypocrisy of Empire and Religion. She famously stated, "*I hate silence when it is time to speak*", and through her gnomic verses we celebrate that the Divine Feminine is opinionated and outspoken, standing up to and speaking out against oppressive systems of patriarchy and capitalism.

In offertory, we sing the Yoik musical tradition of the Indigenous Sámi people of Sápmi, spanning modern day Scandinavia. One of the oldest musical traditions in Europe, yoiking was banned by Lutheran policy from the 17th to 20th centuries, condemned as sinful and demonic. In resistance, groups of Sámi women preserved the tradition through private ceremony and familial agency, leading to a cultural resurgence of the tradition in the 1970s and the passing of legal cultural protections for the Sámi people. This particular yolk is heard in the *Frozen* movies and serves as the musical connection of Elsa and Anna to their mother and her Indigenous roots. Through the singing of Yoik, we assert the

dignity and the insistence of the Divine Feminine in her relationship to the sacred earth and her sacred culture, and her brave commitment to defying its erasure by religious and political systems.

And finally in choral response, we sing the Song of Brigid in celebration of Saint Brigid of Kildare, 5th century Irish activist who created a monastery city system that welcomed all and provided legal protection, shelter, and health care for the imprisoned, the sick, the impoverished, the orphan, and those who had been ousted by patriarchal religious systems. This monastery flourished into a thriving self-governing urban center, becoming the first *Sanctuary City*. In our singing of Saint Brigid, we affirm that the Divine Feminine uses her intellect and civic organization in the work of radical acceptance." ~ *Dr. Ianthe Marini*

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